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Failing with student success: the hidden role of bad luck and false empowerment

Robert Nelson

Monash University Office of Learning and Teaching, Monash University, Melbourne, Australia

ABSTRACT

Conventional wisdom encourages educators to cultivate student success by creating expectations among students, with the intention of boosting motivation and empowerment. If students feel that their learning is in their hands, they are more likely to fulfil the learning outcomes. But this paper argues that vulnerable or sensitive students are paradoxically disempowered when we insist that success is within their control, because the positive emphasis on willpower denies the agency of luck. The paper first examines the structure of success as defined in practice, by students meeting the learning outcomes. The paper then proposes a history of success, which reveals how much the theme of chance or luck lies at the philological heart of the concept. Matching this historical evidence, the student learning experience – and consequently the success within it – is shown to have ineradicable elements of chance and luck. Finally, the paper discusses how Monash honours the theme of empowerment for the sake of student success.

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Introduction

Student success, which is sometimes folded into the theme of retention, invites urgent responses (Fowler & Boylan, 2010; Seidman, 2005). Among the temptations of the educator in this high-stakes field is to encourage students to feel empowered, to feel that their learning is in their own hands, that they can achieve wonderful extremes of success if they have the ambition and have expectations of themselves (Martin, Galentino, & Townsend, 2014). This ode to willpower is already embedded in the motivational rhetoric of schools, locked in competition – just like their students – for high scores, and is rehearsed at university from day zero in speeches during orientation. Student success is related to student empowerment in a somewhat aggressive economy. To motivate students further, we strive to make them feel confident in their goal-setting, with the implication that only their determination and hard work stand between them and their highest aspirations. We encourage students to attach expectations to their hopes, proposing that their resolve, if it is strong enough, will prevail over any adversity. As Vincent Tinto says, we do not rise to low expectations (Tinto, 2012).

CONTACT Robert Nelson robert.nelson@monash.edu
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In this article, I argue that the language of empowerment easily becomes disempowering, especially for sensitive or vulnerable students, and negates the experience that students will already have faced in school and are certain to face again at university. The article seeks to recognize academic dimensions of success that lie outside the control of syllabus design, factors which are not discussed in the literature (Kim, Newton, Downey, & Benton, 2010; Kuh, Kinzie, Buckley, Bridges, & Hayek, 2006, 2011). Using philological methods, the paper identifies a quality of luck or fortune inherent in deeper and earlier conceptions of success which, I argue, are telling and structurally still a part of student success in our age. Despite being long obscured by strategic discourses of empowerment, these dimensions of luck are an intrinsic part of the student learning experience and it is disempowering to exclude them from our view of student success and the messages that we communicate to students. If we contemplate each student's journey, the academic obstacles and dispiriting pressures – just as much as the academic encouragements and stimulation – are disparate, chaotic, subject to chance and luck, and are difficult to regulate or moderate. In this environment, where certain students cannot easily identify themselves as academically successful, it does not help to promote the myth that success is all in their own hands, that they can overcome their feelings of indisposition or inadequacy against adversity simply by applying themselves with greater determination and willpower. With good intentions, we nevertheless subject the most fragile students to the swagger of the most conceited, implicitly holding up their insecurity as a sad and unnecessary impediment to the success that is within their reach. Inadvertently, we create stumble-shaming.

To begin this inquiry, I will first examine the structure of success as defined in practice, by students meeting the learning outcomes. Through this discussion, it emerges that empowerment runs in a slightly different direction to the ideal syllabus design as conceived through constructive alignment. I then propose a history of success, which reveals how much the theme of chance or luck lies at the philological heart of the term. Matching this historical evidence, the student learning experience – and consequently the success within it – is shown to have major and ineradicable elements of chance and luck. Finally, I discuss a circumstance where my colleagues and I at Monash University have been able to intervene helpfully in honouring the theme of empowerment for the sake of student success.

Learning outcomes and the paradox of empowerment

Learning outcomes spell out the capabilities against which students are assessed; and they therefore elegantly set out, in most people's imagination, the terms of success. If you meet all the learning outcomes, you do well. Up to a point, however, meeting the learning outcomes entails intellectual compliance. To that extent, it is a measure of how well you are able to follow instructions, to pinpoint the assessment criteria and strategize their fulfilment; and in this duty of observance, student autonomy – as in the exercise of creativity and imagination – may become a liability. If so, student success, that is, successfully doing as you are told, is paradoxically disempowering. You achieve success not by determining your outcomes but by following and satisfying someone else's.

Before they get into university, students think of success as getting into university. They set their sights on a degree programme and their success at school is measured by whether

or not they are admitted to their first or second preference. The discourse is competition, a striving for high marks that secure an outcome. It sets up a pattern that dominates much of university study as well, especially for any student conscious of the underlying struggle to be selected for higher stakes, to get into further elite programmes such as honours or masters or to win exclusive scholarships for a higher degree by research.

Against these pressing concerns, there is little scope to define success in a more liberal spirit, to propose that intellectual development has an autonomous trajectory proper to each individual and that it bears only a vague relation to the marks that you get at university. Admittedly, high scores will always be an advantage but not to the extent of defining success beyond the degree; and to that extent, there is a question of how artificial the measures of success are within the degree. We would like success to be construed authentically, as often happens in creative disciplines. Students in art or musical composition, for example, know that the marks that they get in their subjects may be to little avail in the field once they leave university. What counts is whether or not they become inspired and make the right connexions, have a sustaining fire in the belly that enjoins their powers of creativity and imagination towards ambitions that best match their talents and identity. This cocktail of insight, intuition and imagination is seen most starkly in creative disciplines but also pervades many other fields that have an entrepreneurial dimension. Success turns out to depend on having ideas rather than following instructions, listening to one's ambient culture and judging the best opportunities with the most fertile suite of possibilities. Success involves handling things that have not been prefigured. If anything, success in imaginative pursuits depends on transcending the methods and parameters of success at university, that is, meeting the stipulated learning outcomes; because part of the profession is thinking of your own outcomes according to circumstances greatly affected by lucky opportunities.

However, seizing on opportunities, which could be described as a talent, is not what I mean by academic luck. Rather, it is a happy coincidence or a lack of it, from which you can profit or not. An example might be subject selection. Imagine a first year humanities student who decides to take Logic alongside humanities subjects like Philosophy, on the basis that she is not bad at maths, achieving a good mark at school. She has a laudable attitude of wanting to challenge herself and is given every encouragement in this academically worthy ambition. Alas, after census date (the last occasion for free withdrawal from a subject), she struggles and ends up failing the subject. In hindsight, she could have taken Italian, say, and augmented her knowledge and skills and cultural competence enormously; but instead, she ends up with nothing but the awareness that she is not suited to mathematical logic, making her feel like a failure and somewhat denting her confidence.

In the face of this debacle, we could say that she was not prudent. But blaming the student, or even her advisors or ambient culture, is a complacent analysis. If it turned out that our student had been a good logician, we would be applauding her courage and various people along the way would seek to take credit for her success. There would have been no way of telling what aptitude she had for the subject, beyond working at it, not giving up and pushing herself. It seemed not a bad decision at the time; it just turned out to be an unlucky choice. It is not really a question of prudence; otherwise, we would always recommend the safest, blandest, most unadventurous options; no one would be minded for discovery and any degree of unnecessary risk would be discouraged. For our student, however, it is important not to impute the fail

to a lack of insight, a dumb fantasy, a fault in prudence. It is better to say that it was an unlucky choice, allowing the student to move on, to bounce back, to countenance the pain with the consolation of fortune.

Not only is this sympathetic narrative sweeter for the student but it is more honest from the educator, given that we are not soothsayers: we lack the clairvoyance to know what anyone will be able to do, even if it were possible to influence everyone who risks making the wrong decision. Finally, the confession of luck is also more truthful to the inner structure of success, which is revealed by two millennia in the development of language. Deep in the history of ideas, when the concept of success arose, there is a telling link between success and luck, where the relationship between success and outcomes is uncannily the opposite to the alignment that we know in education today.

A history of success

The idea of success did not always exist. Success as a good outcome had to be specified as good, just as we have to do with outcome. An outcome can be good or bad and there is no absolute. We cannot say: Josephine 'had outcome' in the way that we say Josephine 'had success'. This movement of success from a relative concept to an absolute is comparatively new in the history of ideas.

The deeper motif of success, as revealed in the history of language, concerns things following one another, or 'succeeding' one another, towards an *unknown outcome*. For example, William Shakespeare, who did not use the word 'outcome', nevertheless spoke of much the same concept using the word 'success'. In *Antony and Cleopatra*, a war is reported which Enobarbus already knows about; so he says of the news: 'This is old: what is the success?' (*Antony and Cleopatra* 3.5). That means: what is the outcome, similar to Shakespeare's 'dangerous success of bloody wars' (*Richard III* 4.4). You might think that the bard was sloppy with words: surely *the war* is dangerous, not the success. But for the baroque poet, the success is dangerous because it is unknown. Success in our terms cannot easily involve peril, because it has already succeeded; but the early modern understanding of the term is infused with doubt, where we are not sure which way the contest will go. In a discussion among the powerful in the French dramatist Racine, we wait upon the success of their talks ('de leur entrevue attendre le succès', *Bajazet* 1.4). The success, in that sense, could be terrible. Success is therefore always newsworthy on account of its suspense; and when it is positive, the sentiment is declared with adjectives or adverbs that predicate it as favourable, like 'good' or 'happy': ('The king hath happily receiv'd … the news of thy success', *Macbeth* 1.3).

It is by no means a quirk of our language. English follows the example of the Romance languages. The Italian word for success (*successo*) also means 'happened', because any event in time happens after another and follows from it. In periods that felt the fickleness of fortune more keenly than our own, the outcome of any event is defined as a success without necessarily being in our favour. The outcome of war is notoriously unpredictable, as the sixteenth-century poet Ludovico Ariosto said well before Shakespeare: 'how different is the result of battles (*il fin successe*, literally "how the end succeeds", from what you would have believed beforehand!' (*Orlando furioso* 10.54). Elsewhere, the poet asks, 'now hear the ending (*il successo*) of the story' where the ending is 'the success', what follows to the end (*Orlando furioso* 26.68).

There is another term for success in Italian (*riuscita*) but it also contains the same motif of doubt about the outcome. The fourteenth-century Giovanni Boccaccio often uses the phrase 'to see how things want to end' ('*aspettando a che riuscir volesse*', *Decameron* 2.10, 3.3, 7.8, cf. later Matteo Bandello, *Novelle* 1.15, 1.44). Using the verbal form for success, people can 'finish' their stories (*essendo ciascuno della brigata della sua novella riuscito*, 6.10) or the term can come to a cruel ending (*a crudel fine riuscivano le parole*). Boccaccio speaks of a splendid success (*splendida riuscita*, 2.4) which really means happy outcome, as if the outcome could have been less splendid. In the sixteenth-century courtly writer Baldassare Castiglione, some men are described as left standing in plenty of suspense (*stettero assai sospesi*), waiting for where the matter would end up or 'succeed' ('*dove la cosa avesse a riuscire*', *Cortegiano* 2.48). In the same century, too, Bandello uses the verb for success to describe things ending up at the wretched pass that occurred ('*riuscito cosí vituperoso fine come ne uscí*', *Novelle* 1.10), which duplicates the root of issuing (*uscire*). In Bandello, too, things can happen in vain (*riuscita indarno*, 1.45), literally succeed in vain, though it seems like a contradiction in terms today. The same is true in French, where the verb (*réussir*) usually translates as succeed in the modern sense but not necessarily. For example, in the foreword that the seventeenth-century Pierre Corneille wrote for his play *La place royale*, things can go badly, literally, 'it succeeds badly' (*réussit mal*); and to say that things succeed well, La Bruyère says in the same century that they have not succeeded badly (*qui ne leur a pas mal réussi*, *Les caractères*, or *mauvais succès*. 3.39). As in contemporary usage, one can say that things succeed in going badly or, as La Bruyère says, succeed in annoying me ('*a pu réussir à m'ennuyer*', *Les caractères* 2.47).

Deeper still in the history of success, we see what lies behind the uncertainty: it is an element of luck that is nigh expunged from the concept today. But the presence of luck is conspicuous in ancient language. In Greek, the key conceptions for success are based upon a root for fate or destiny (τύχη, *LSJ s.v.*) or to hit upon, gain one's end or purpose and hence succeed (τυγχάνω) with an air of luck, as if happening to be in the right place at the right time. Key conceptions of success contain this particle (εὐτύχημα, εὐτυχία) with verbal (εὐτυχέω) and adjectival forms (εὐτυχής). To be unsuccessful or experience ill-success was also linked to luck (δυσποτμία) through another root for fate or destiny (πότμος), literally that which befalls one, from the verb for falling (πίπτω). Success could also be conceived in terms of a target, hitting the mark (ἐπίσκοπος, εὐεπίτευκτος) and going directly to it, right on, success as a straight shot (κατόρθωμα), performed by one who successfully accomplishes something (κατορθωτής).

The later forms of success retain something of this sense of a lucky turn, a happy and well-met result or outcome. The Italian term for success considered above (*riuscita*) has its origins in the Latin to 'come out' (*exire*) or have an outcome. It carries the sense of 'what emerges' (or what 'issues', which contains the Latin root *exire*, or proceeds from), an eventuality that has an outcome which could be favourable. The link with modern languages is seen best in Spanish, where the expression for success (*tener éxito*) is almost unchanged from the Latin root. It is literally to 'hold outcome'. And in many ways, this strangely mechanistic motif – where something goes in and something comes out or issues forth – is replicated in the conception by which we pre-eminently speak of a good outcome, namely our word 'success'. In its origins, to succeed in Latin (*succedo*) means to go under, enter or come under something, like a roof. It might mean to ascend or submit

but also to advance, march up to or approach, and finally to follow or to enter into a relation (Lewis & Short *s.v.*). The root (*cedo*) means to cede or yield and is elastic, leading to other abstract words that designate weak actions, like concede, accede and recede.

An interesting pattern emerges. Success has equivocal origins, riddled with chance and luck, that match a feeling of uncertainty within us as to what success really is. It is as if language, since archaic times, had prefigured all our agonies, because it reflects the difficulty of formulating something which is uncertain until it comes to a happy conclusion. The historical uncertainty also reflects an ambivalence within our psyche: to succeed in the sense of follow – and so resign ourselves to institutional conformity – or to succeed in becoming an autonomous intellectual agent? And all of this even before we ask: success at what? To succeed in one endeavour might mean to fail in another. The field is highly dialectical. Your success is contingent and often attends upon many decisions and values. A part of success is therefore to opt boldly for something that profits you or your group or community. Success in that sense means a kind of leading of events, leadership in the sense of initiative and imagination for some creative impetus that leads to a beautiful purpose. But it always occurs to a backdrop of risk, chance, uncertainty, and is not really a success if it does not undergo, as it were, this rite of passage through the random.

To me, the deeper historical backdrop of success is instructive in reminding us of the non-fixity of student success in our day which is somewhat obscured by the air of certainty established by learning outcomes. In the renaissance, success equates with hazard, not certainty. Further, the concept of something succeeding often had no positive connotations, as in whatever happens in a contest, be it good or bad (*o bene o mal successe, Orlando furioso 33.7*); as we have seen, things in the renaissance often succeed badly or happen badly ('e poi che mal la cosa l'è successa', *Orlando furioso* 25.10) just as they succeed well ('dove ebbe all'ardir suo sì buon successo', *Orlando furioso* 20.57). The character of renaissance and baroque success is nothing like our modern idea of success as a win or great result, a gain or coup or profitable stroke. In the renaissance and baroque, success is what ensues from a narrative dilemma where things could either be favourable or rotten. Success is to be foretold and invokes the spirit of prophecy, as when Caesar asks: 'Go bid the priests do present sacrifice, / And bring me their opinions of success' (*Julius Caesar* 2.2). Their opinions are whether or not the outcome could be favourable. Success is not exactly an outcome. It has a predestined air, where luck is in play and events that follow one another share the quality of providence. In the development of language, success is related to the motif of following, which you can also see in other languages like German, where success (*Erfolg*) is derived from the verb to follow (*folgen*); and our own word is shadowed with the motif of following, as the forms 'successive' or 'succession' demonstrate, like Shakespeare's 'successively from blood to blood' (*Richard III* 3.7) or 'plead my successive title with your swords' (*Titus Andronicus* 1.1).

Language has subsequently purged success of the element of chance or hazard, to the point that success is always positive, which is why we talk about student success (as opposed to failure, withdrawal and disappointment) and why we seek to narrow the hazards through specifying learning outcomes as a strongly positive result of studying. Our learning outcomes are the ideal, which is why we also call them intended learning outcomes: they are the result which would be most desirable. So to that extent, they reflect the

later evolution of the word success, which we have finally enshrined in the institution of 'student success'. Is it possible to revisit this term, with its strong link with retention, and instead identify success with a more inflected suite of chancy factors, true to the deeper origins of success, as we now know the term embodied in previous centuries?

The structure of academic luck

Student success is not linear. At each stage, the academic experience of each student is infused with chance, with good or bad luck, with the happy preparedness to fathom something or, with the turn of fortune's wheel, a lack of confidence, a wall of despondency and frustration. We like to think that students do well because (i) they are smart, (ii) they put in the requisite effort and (iii) we teach them effectively, with excellent scaffolding and safety nets. It sounds so fair and reasonable, giving due recognition to their brains, their energy and our wisdom and labour as teachers. But when I compare this symmetrical ideal with the bumpy reality, it seems more like a fantasy than a correct account of the learning experience.

Especially in junior years, many students wrestle with feelings of alienation. They do not always belong with the syllabus in the way that the lecturers do and nor do they shape up well next to the sophisticated students, the ones who adroitly answer questions in class and seem to do well almost without effort. If I think back, I remember the struggle to gain a voice. The tutors have no idea where I am coming from. They do not relate to my humour and I find theirs to be pompous. There are strong cultural divisions that operate, if not class distinctions as well. I can see that the students who seem to excel are all familiar with the syllabus in a way that I am not. They are lucky. Their maturity also gives them an advantage. But it is not an equity discourse, because I do not come from a disadvantaged sector. Rather, it is about a private confidence that my cultural background aligns or sits at variance with the syllabus; and this background may or may not come with privilege. Axiomatically, the students who can identify with the syllabus are the ones who do well; and in this identification, there is little by way of brain or work: rather, it is the coincidence of a fantasy and a body of thought, an image of what I might become that mysteriously aligns with the subject matter. In earlier times, such alignments were called 'aptitude'; but such quaint terms that throw the onus onto the student's makeup do not recognize the element of chance that operates and rather give the impression of the student being congenitally suited to the syllabus.

As a student, my personality counts for more than I care to recognize. When I smile at the tutor and she or he smiles back or has a ready thought to engage me – as if thinking what I am thinking – my academic fortunes have just improved. There is so much security in the feeling of a rapport. As a result of those few seconds of shared faith, I carry around an optimism for months that I have great potential to latch onto the things that matter most in the academy. If, on the other hand, I struggle to get the tutor's attention and she or he seems unaccountably deaf when I talk, I feel a bit like an idiot, someone destined to remain insignificant and inept in the discipline. I do not feel a rush of enthusiasm. I get the feeling that these people would just as soon I did something else in another department. They do not especially want me here. If they were not forced to have me in their class, they would exclude me. My mediocre marks are a testament to their disdain. In their eyes, I am may not exactly be worthless but ever so slightly a waste of the tutor's

time. And with this suspicion hanging over the confidence in me that I impute to my tutor, I do not easily see how I can improve my chances.

Academics can be fair with all their processes but they cannot so easily control their encouragement because the impulse to share their zeal is a genuine expression of their own enthusiasm. It cannot be fudged. It is obvious to all if a teacher tries to generate enthusiasm artificially; and it is painful for us as academics to have to feign any kind of faith. You resent the need to pretend. If, on the other hand, a student is imaginative in the way that you find rewarding, you become personally excited. You feel a connexion. These instances of connexion are somewhat random, difficult to recognize, much less control. There are subjective energies operating throughout the on-campus experience which determine the key attitudes to study which, in turn, inform student success. They are outside the grid of syllabus design; they have nothing to do with constructive alignment or learning outcomes or blended modes or active learning or learning in groups or learning with technology or any of the shibboleths that we are inclined to think would make such a difference to the student learning experience and hence to student success.

It is not a question of personal charm or a twinkle in the eye but a match in proclivities that arises by chance between student and tutor. Imagine a subject or unit that is taught by two tutors. The first tutor is keen on structure and focus, is punctilious and pedantic about referencing and anxiously demands that students follow conventions, marking student papers in a somewhat intolerant spirit when rules are not observed and especially when the paper is colourful and narrates the student's personal experience.

The second tutor, on the other hand, is relaxed about the rules and is more concerned with content and creative potential. The second tutor responds warmly in detecting the individual voice of the student and despises run-of-the-mill essays that begin with 'In this essay, I will … ' The second tutor enjoys imagery, personal experience, a phenomenological interpretation that comes directly from the student's imagination. Consequently, there is little anxiety over conventions that were so much the preoccupation of the first tutor. If an imaginative student gets the second tutor, it is pure luck. If he or she gets the first tutor, it is unadulterated bad luck.

Theoretically, the architecture of learning outcomes and marking rubrics that respect them guarantees consistency of assessment and levels out the discrepancies with agreed criteria on all pieces of work. Alas, the marking rubric only creates layers of illusion that consistency has been instituted. The first tutor, having decided from the essay that the student is wayward, will mark the student down on all categories, including soft criteria such as 'imagination' or 'originality' because the writing does not appeal and so even by these subjective measures, the aim will be judged to have been mismanaged. Meanwhile, the second tutor, experiencing delight over the imaginative potential and originality of the student, will boost the marks on all the hard criteria, such as 'research' or 'evidence' because all the phenomenological inventive material will be ascribed to them.

The marking rubric is made of wood where the thought of teacher and student alike is mercurial. The second tutor (and I was one of them) feels that an interesting essay, an essay with imaginative promise or poetic expression, trumps the marking rubric. We are interested in the student going beyond all the published criteria, which is an unspoken licence that I shared with my professor, a kind of secret that can never logically be revealed. If we say 'marks will be awarded by the student going beyond the published criteria', the

published criteria would no longer enjoy credibility, because they include the call to transcend them, to encompass sources and ideas beyond the resources provided or suggested. Further, if we did disseminate an invitation to go beyond the published criteria, the distinguishing intrepid element would no longer be about the student's initiative or conceptual daring but yet another manipulative skill on the part of any calculating student.

For a student genuinely to use initiative means taking risks, and these risks are rewarded by luck as well as skill and knowledge. No matter how prudent the student may be, there is limited scope in eliminating the element of chance. Since the renaissance, success is composed of virtues like diligence, study and intelligence and then there is pot luck. Machiavelli estimated that fate or fortune determines half of our actions (che la fortuna sia arbitra della metà delle azioni nostre, *Il principe* 25). Nothing has changed now that we have learning outcomes and marking rubrics. There is an attempt through these worthy instruments to stay the element of luck, to reduce it in mechanical operation, because no one enjoys the arbitrary and no university can afford to say: 'success in your studies at our academy will depend substantially on luck'. We unconsciously hide the reality, concealing the arbitrary components of success even from ourselves. But all that we have achieved is to reduce the visibility of luck. Success is sanitized by an air of responsibility; but the element of luck that naturally spooks success has not been reduced and we are deceiving ourselves to imagine that success involves less luck than it ever did in the past. As a result, we have generated a culture that expects a certainty around success that it cannot have; and with the inevitable disappointment there is not only bitterness and resentment but heightened fragility in the individuals who cannot boast the success of others.

Earlier European cultures – and other world cultures, for that matter, with Buddhist or Confucian origins – have made their peace with luck. It went without saying that success was in part a matter of chance or, as Machiavelli repeated so often, that any happy condition occurs either by earning it or by fortune ('*o per fortuna o per virtù*', *Il principe* 1). The component that is determined by fate cannot be corrected or forestalled by human prudence; it is without remedy (*Il principe* 25). We have difficulty accepting this reality, obvious even in the highly regulated sphere of education. If I am in a class full of apprehensive and timid students, I stand out and my tutor loves my contributions. If I am in a class full of ambitious and confident students, I am myself reticent in the face of their competition and become diffident and unassertive. I do not distinguish myself as I did in the other class where I have all the advantages and charm. It is the same me, the same syllabus, the same learning outcomes served by constructive alignment and marking rubrics, just an entirely different experience and economy of favour determined by fate.

But now that we have banished any sense of luck or fortune from the construct of success, students have no means of reassuring themselves when suddenly they find themselves indisposed, embarrassed, disempowered, falling short of the mark. No natural philosophy takes care of their pain and no natural consolations attend their slide into mediocrity. Nothing insulates their ego from a downturn, because they can no longer put their setbacks down to bad luck. They accuse themselves of dereliction and personal failure when in fact unlucky circumstances are to blame. With all our architecture of educational control – all professed in impeccable good faith – we have trashed the natural and ancient concept of success as something that happens legitimately by design or by luck.

A creative approach to the problem

At my university, Associate Prof Angela Carbone, Tristan Cui and I run a module for academic staff called 'Supporting Student Success' through the Continuing Education Excellence Development (CEED) programme, where we try to establish the separate value of framing student success as opposed to the equally valuable job of keeping track of wayward students and keeping them on a productive path. Under the theme of 'Student empowerment', we define student success as the ability of students to determine their own sense of a beneficial experience. For most students, we freely admit, success translates to the tangible achievement of gaining the degree in some creditworthy way, sometimes modestly and sometimes ambitiously; but we do not foreclose on the student's autonomy in revising the terms of success, which might even include some suspicion of the stated learning outcomes of any given unit.

At Monash, we have had the opportunity to challenge the uninflected mechanistic view of success that aligns success either with scoring high grades or not dropping out. How can we help our students expand their consciousness of success in an enlightened direction, so that it is not just about marks but also takes into account the unimaginable factors that previous centuries called fortune? The module that Angela and Tristan teach with me serves many purposes, which are spelled out in its learning outcomes. Upon completing, participants are expected to be able to (i) articulate what student success means for the individual and from an institutional perspective, (ii) discuss factors that prevent students achieving success, (iii) apply a number of strategies that can be implemented to improve student success, including supplemental instruction and finally (iv) use some basic analytical reports to detect early warning signs. The reports from the learning management system offer an extremely tangible indication of student engagement, which is also a strong predictor of student success. We believe that the information is useful and can be used to help at-risk students; and retention is hardly a trivial matter that we can afford to ignore. However, for the first and second learning outcomes – to articulate what student success means and to discuss factors that prevent students achieving success – we encourage our academics to see beyond the dashboard into a more chaotic world where success is buffeted by the winds and flux of fortune, as Machiavelli says (*Il principe* 18).

Among our intentions is the keenness for academics to resist passing on to students the myth that success is something totally within their control, which would be a discourse of false empowerment. False empowerment arises when we seek to motivate people by insisting that they have the willpower and the personal resources to overcome any obstacle. You just need the ambition and then the determination. The unspoken corollary is that if you are not achieving some identifiably ambitious success, you are deficient in willpower and resolve.

To offset this unwittingly demoralizing emphasis on an empowerment that undermines the confidence of the faltering, our module begins by asking participants how they imagined themselves as students. We ask the participants to rank themselves relative to one another according to how successful they were as students. They are amused to discover that they all felt as insecure as one another; and there is much jostling for the centre of 'not very' either way. Now highly published academics at a top-rank university, many confess that their academic experience was very mixed and that they did not experience much

sense of success till much later in the piece. They variously felt disappointed in themselves, either by following templates and scoring well – but not exercising any of the imagination that would later give them success to be proud of – or attempting to be creative and being punished for the audacity by mediocre marks. This exercise establishes the great relativity of success, how fugitive it is, how seldom it assists our sense of self-worth, at least until (by some lucky point) we break through with accelerated confidence. And so too with our students.

The module then exhaustively examines the several ways that we can look after students, even in large numbers, using the digital monitoring that is now ubiquitous in universities. The intention of this survey of the available resources is to figure out what kinds of intervention are helpful according to the kinds of information that can be obtained. We seek encouraging language which, however, does not cross the line into motivational rhetoric of false empowerment; because in all likelihood, our students who are behind are experiencing some kind of awful luck. It may be that indeed some superhuman feat of willpower will enable them to transcend and overcome their rotten luck; but we cannot assume that this is possible or even likely. If any assumptions are to be made, it is best to begin with the belief that the more vulnerable students have begun with as much willpower as the successful ones but have encountered some bad luck that the happy students have had the good fortune to avoid. Given that our academics have themselves experienced great lows which are neither owing to flagging willpower nor – we know for certain – any weakness of intellect, we can imagine that some sympathetic rapport might be discovered in conversing with the student. Our aim is not just to chase students. It is framed as helping them; and sometimes the best way (which we are somewhat resistant to recognizing, thanks to our own belief in the robustness of syllabus design) is to acknowledge that some kind of bad luck is involved.

The final exercise that we propose is to frame various scenarios where academics might be giving advice to students at different extremes: those hungry and ambitious students who define success as scoring high grades, to those more romantic happy-go-lucky souls who have never thought about success or goal-setting, to those who are diffident, scared, full of trepidation about their academic fate, who already feel out of their depth and anxious even in talking about success. The intention in contemplating these scenarios is again to deflect the impulse to adopt motivational rhetoric, even with the ambitious students who seem already to be determined and, like talented athletes, could be spurred on to become champions. We would rather suggest to these greyhound personalities that while they continue to pursue their ambitions with maximum energy and determination, the study does not need to be construed as a racecourse but that time can be taken to absorb imaginative perspectives that do not necessarily lead just to acing the assessments but provide conversational interest for a lifetime.

Our CEED programme is organized around several themes and the module 'Supporting Student Success' is placed under the banner of 'Student Empowerment'. By student empowerment, we understand everything *but* motivational rhetoric, the 'you can do it' line which has a paradoxically discouraging effect on those who are dubious about their chances. High among the aims of student empowerment is the hope that students can apply their own imagination to the learning experience, leading to high levels of ownership in learning. We believe that this student-centred approach, where we identify student empowerment with the imaginative ownership of the syllabus, is a better way to achieve

greater levels of student success than further machinery to conceal the element of luck, which will continue regardless of our strategies to exclude it.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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Note that pre-industrial sources are cited by the lexicographical conventions of philology, e.g., *Matthew* 2.5, so that they do not depend on editions. Plays are cited by act and scene, poems by canto, stanza and line, *novelle* and essays by book and story and so on.

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